EDITORIAL SERIES · WHAT COUNTS IN THE AGE OF AI? · PART 4 OF 10

What Counts as Teaching in the Age of AI?

Why the value of teaching lies not in answers, but in relationships and judgement.

By Dr Jabreel Asghar · 17 August 2026

A student looked at my written feedback and asked whether it had been generated by AI. The implication was clear: if AI had written it, it was not truly my feedback. What surprised me was not the question itself, but what it revealed—how quickly AI has begun to reshape our understanding of teaching. Should AI-generated feedback matter if its quality had not changed? If it was just as useful as teacher-generated feedback, why did its perceived source reduce its value? Does educational value lie in the feedback itself, or in the human relationship that the feedback represents?

Perhaps students are not evaluating only information because the value of feedback has always depended on more than its quality. It also depends on students believing that someone read their work, exercised professional judgement, understood their difficulties, and cared enough to respond personally. AI may reproduce the informational content of feedback, but teaching also carries relational value. Students are not merely interpreting comments; they are interpreting evidence of professional attention and judgement. That is part of what gives teaching its professional legitimacy.

For generations, teachers derived authority from possessing knowledge, explaining concepts, evaluating students, and controlling access to information. AI has weakened the traditional signs by which students identify professional judgement. It has changed the basis on which students recognise teaching itself, raising questions about trust, authenticity, professional identity, and pedagogical expertise. In this new context, the central issue is no longer whether teachers use AI, but how students interpret the presence of AI in acts of teaching.

If students begin to assume that thoughtful feedback, carefully crafted explanations, or detailed comments are AI-generated, what happens to the recognition of teachers' professional judgement? The wrong question to ask is whether students still need teachers at all. Perhaps the real question is this: did students ever need teachers primarily because teachers possessed information? Students have never needed teachers simply because information was scarce. They needed teachers because educational judgement cannot be reduced to information alone. Teachers have always facilitated what they provided to learners; now they will facilitate what learners access. This progression—from providing answers to cultivating judgement—is far more profound and substantive than traditional professional development.

Ultimately, AI does not render teachers obsolete. It invites them to reconsider where their professional value truly lies—not in the answers they give, but in the relationships they build and the judgement they cultivate. When my student questioned whether my feedback had been written by AI, the issue was never the quality of the feedback. It was whether the professional judgement behind it was recognised as human. That may become one of the defining challenges of teaching in the age of AI.

About this editorial

This editorial examines what happens to the meaning of teaching when AI can reproduce explanations, feedback, and other forms of instructional support. It argues that the distinctive value of teaching lies not simply in providing information, but in professional judgement, relational trust, and helping learners develop judgement of their own.

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